

Haligric Research Integration Series

Pentecostalism

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

The Spirit Poured Out — Azusa Street, the Gifts, and the Global Fire

On the night of April 9, 1906, at a house on Bonnie Brae Street in Los Angeles, one person began to speak in tongues, then six others. They shouted so loudly that the neighborhood was alerted. Within days, thousands were coming. A former slave's son was leading the revival, and in the segregated America of 1906, black hands were being laid on white heads.

In 1906 there were no Pentecostals. By 2025 there were approximately 700 million. No movement in the history of Christianity has grown as fast. It is now the dominant form of Christianity in Latin America, sub-Saharan Africa, and South Korea, and one of the primary forces reshaping global religion in the 21st century.

William Seymour told his congregation: "Don't go out of here talking about tongues: talk about Jesus." The fire he started consumed the world anyway.

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Introduction — What Is Pentecostalism?

Pentecostalism is the fastest-growing religious movement in the history of Christianity — a tradition that did not exist before 1901, reached approximately 700 million adherents by 2025, and currently represents approximately one quarter to one third of all Christians worldwide when its charismatic variants are included. It is the dominant form of Christianity in Latin America, sub-Saharan Africa, South Korea, and significant portions of Southeast Asia. In the United States it encompasses the largest Black church tradition (the Church of God in Christ), the fastest-growing White evangelical denomination (the Assemblies of God), and a vast landscape of independent megachurches, storefront congregations, and house churches that defy any single organizational description.

What makes Pentecostalism distinctive is not primarily its doctrine of salvation (which is broadly evangelical — salvation by grace through faith in Christ alone) but its specific convictions about the ongoing availability and expected presence of the supernatural in the life of the believer and the church. Pentecostals believe that the spiritual gifts described in the New Testament — speaking in tongues, prophecy, healing, miracles, words of knowledge and wisdom — are not historical relics from the apostolic era but present realities available to all believers in every age. They believe that the baptism of the Holy Spirit — a distinct experience of divine empowerment subsequent to conversion — is normative for the Christian life, typically evidenced by speaking in tongues. And they believe that the God of the Bible is actively, supernaturally present in the gathered community — healing bodies, speaking prophetically, and transforming lives — not merely in ancient history but right now.

This document covers: the Holiness movement roots; Charles Parham and the Topeka revival; William Seymour and Azusa Street in full narrative detail; the fourfold and fivefold gospel; the baptism of the Holy Spirit; glossolalia (speaking in tongues) and its theology; all nine gifts of the Spirit individually; divine healing; the fivefold ministry; Pentecostal soteriology; Oneness Pentecostalism; Pentecostal worship in complete step-by-step detail; prayer in Pentecostal life; the charismatic renewal; neo-Pentecostalism and the Word of Faith movement; the prosperity gospel and its theology and controversies; the Assemblies of God; the Church of God in Christ; global Pentecostalism; the Global South; Pentecostalism and social justice; and the Haligricity Lens.

Roots — The Holiness Movement and Charles Parham

Pentecostalism did not emerge from nowhere. Its immediate roots lie in the 19th-century Holiness movement — the widespread revival of Wesleyan theology of entire sanctification that produced camp meetings, Holiness denominations, and a culture of expectancy about the continuing work of the Holy Spirit. The Holiness movement had inherited from John Wesley the conviction that God could fill a human being with the Holy Spirit in a definite crisis experience of entire sanctification, and it had extended this conviction into an increasingly pneumatological (Spirit-centered) direction. By the 1880s and 1890s, many Holiness preachers were speaking of a "baptism of the Holy Spirit and fire" — an experience that would empower believers for witnessing and service and that would be accompanied by supernatural signs.

The specific theological link between the Holiness tradition and Pentecostalism is Charles Fox Parham (1873-1929), a white Holiness minister in Kansas who asked a crucial and ultimately world-changing question: What is the biblical evidence that a person has received the baptism of the Holy Spirit? In 1900, Parham assigned his students at Bethel Bible College in Topeka, Kansas, to study Acts 2 and the other accounts of Spirit-baptism in Acts and the Epistles. On January 1, 1901, a student named Agnes Ozman asked Parham to lay hands on her and pray for her to receive the baptism of the Holy Spirit. She began to speak in tongues — and for three days reportedly could not speak English at all. Soon other students followed.

Parham drew the conclusion that has defined Pentecostalism ever since: speaking in tongues (glossolalia) is the "initial physical evidence" of the baptism of the Holy Spirit — the specific sign that accompanies and confirms this experience. This theological claim — that tongues is not merely one possible gift among many but the defining evidence of Spirit-baptism — is the most characteristic and most controversial Pentecostal doctrine, and it originated with Parham in Topeka in 1901.

Parham subsequently established a Bible school in Houston, Texas, where he maintained racial segregation in his classroom practices — a fact of enormous irony given what was about to happen. Among those who sat in the hallway outside the classroom door, listening through the doorway, was a young Black Holiness preacher named William Joseph Seymour.

William Seymour — The Son of Former Slaves

William Joseph Seymour (1870-1922) was born in Centerville, Louisiana, the son of Sim and Phyllis Seymour, both former slaves. He had grown up in the post-Reconstruction South, experienced severe smallpox that left him blind in one eye, and through his spiritual journey had moved through Catholic, Methodist, and Holiness environments before encountering Parham's teaching on the baptism of the Holy Spirit in Houston in 1905.

What Seymour received from Parham was the doctrine of tongues as initial evidence of Spirit-baptism — a doctrine he had not yet personally experienced, but which he embraced and began to preach. In early 1906, he was invited to Los Angeles to help pastor a small Holiness mission. He arrived and preached his first sermon on Acts 2 — making the case that tongues was the biblical evidence of the Holy Spirit's baptism. The church promptly locked him out: the doctrine was too radical, too disruptive. Seymour began holding cottage prayer meetings with a small group of seekers at the home of Richard and Ruth Asberry on Bonnie Brae Street.

On the night of April 9, 1906, the breakthrough came. One person began to speak in tongues, then six others. They shouted so loudly that the neighborhood was alerted. People came from all over the neighborhood to see what was happening. Seymour himself did not speak in tongues until April 12. Within days the crowds had outgrown the Asberry home, and Seymour moved the meetings to a dilapidated former African Methodist Episcopal church building at 312 Azusa Street in the industrial district of downtown Los Angeles.

The Azusa Street Revival — 1906

The Azusa Street Mission became one of the most significant addresses in the history of Christianity. From April 1906 through approximately 1909, meetings ran from mid-morning to midnight, seven days a week. There was no fixed order of service — worship erupted spontaneously, with people singing, praying, speaking in tongues, testifying, and falling to the floor under what participants described as the weight of the Spirit's presence. There was no regular collection. Seymour often sat behind a wooden box with two shoe crates stacked on top — and sometimes with his head inside the box in prayer — while the meeting carried itself.

What made Azusa Street globally significant was not only the spiritual intensity but the racial composition of the gathering. In the Jim Crow America of 1906, when racial separation was enforced by law and sustained by violence, the Azusa Street Mission was integrated. Black worshippers and white worshippers knelt together, prayed together, wept together, and received the Holy Spirit together. Black hands were laid on white heads in prayer. Women and men led services together. The Los Angeles Times, covering the revival in April 1906, was scandalized: its headline called the meeting "a disgraceful intermingling of the races" and described Seymour with contemptuous condescension as "an old colored exhorter, blind in one eye."

Seymour's own theological vision was bigger than tongues. He repeatedly admonished his congregation: "Don't go out of here talking about tongues: talk about Jesus." The racial integration of the revival was, for him, as significant a sign of the Spirit's power as the speaking in tongues — perhaps more significant. He believed that the Spirit was breaking down the walls of race, denomination, class, and gender that divided the church. The Apostolic Faith newspaper (the revival's publication) proclaimed: "Pentecost has come. The color line was washed away in the blood."

The Azusa Street Revival ended around 1909, partly due to the departure of Florence Crawford with the mailing list of the Apostolic Faith newsletter (depriving the mission of its network), and partly due to the increasing racial re-segregation of the revival as white Pentecostals came to dominate and then displace Black leadership. But by then the fire had been spread: hundreds of "Azusa Pilgrims" had visited from across the United States and from other countries, received the Pentecostal experience, and returned to their home communities to start new Pentecostal churches and movements. Within a decade, Pentecostalism had spread to Europe, Latin America, Asia, and Africa. Within a century, it had 700 million adherents.

The Fourfold Gospel — Saved, Sanctified, Healed, Coming King

The theological framework of classical Pentecostalism is typically summarized as the "Fourfold Gospel" (in its Wesleyan/Holiness form) or the "Full Gospel" — a package of four core convictions about what Christ has accomplished for believers:

1. **JESUS SAVES:** Salvation through personal repentance and faith in Christ's atoning work — the evangelical conviction shared with all Protestant Christianity. In Pentecostalism, this conversion experience is typically vivid and definable, often emotional, and understood as the starting point of a transforming relationship with God.
2. **JESUS SANCTIFIES** (in the Wesleyan/Holiness Pentecostal form): The work of entire sanctification — the purification of the heart from the power of sin — is available as a second definite work of grace subsequent to conversion. This is the Wesleyan inheritance in classical Pentecostalism; not all Pentecostals (particularly those from a Baptist/Reformed background) affirm this element, producing "two-stage" (salvation + Spirit baptism) rather than "three-stage" (salvation + sanctification + Spirit baptism) Pentecostalism.
3. **JESUS HEALS:** Physical healing is available as a provision of Christ's atoning work. The scriptural basis is Isaiah 53:4-5 ("Surely he has borne our griefs and carried our sorrows... and by his wounds we are healed") and Matthew 8:16-17 (Jesus healing the sick as fulfillment of Isaiah's prophecy). Divine healing is not something God occasionally grants by special providence; it is part of what Christ accomplished at the cross, available by faith for those who receive it. This conviction drives the healing ministries, healing lines, and anointing services that are characteristic features of Pentecostal worship.
4. **JESUS IS COMING KING:** The imminent, premillennial return of Christ is expected and urgently prepared for. Pentecostalism emerged in the context of premillennialist eschatology — the expectation that history is near its end, that Christ will return to establish his kingdom, and that the restoration of the spiritual gifts is one of the signs of the last days. The urgency of the end times has historically fueled Pentecostal evangelism: there is no time to waste; Christ is coming; people must be saved.

Many Pentecostals, particularly those associated with the International Church of the Foursquare Gospel (founded by Aimee Semple McPherson in 1927), use a fivefold rather than fourfold pattern, separating Spirit-baptism from sanctification as a distinct element. The specific formula varies by tradition; the underlying vision is consistent: Jesus is the complete Savior, addressing every dimension of human need — spiritual, ethical, physical, and eschatological.

The Baptism of the Holy Spirit

The baptism of the Holy Spirit is the central distinctive of Pentecostal theology and the experience that defines the movement. It is a distinct work of the Spirit, subsequent to and separate from conversion, through which the believer receives a specific empowerment for witness and service — and which is evidenced by speaking in tongues. The scriptural basis is primarily the Acts narrative: in Acts 2 the disciples receive the Spirit on Pentecost and speak in tongues; in Acts 8 the Samaritans receive the Spirit through the laying on of hands; in Acts 10 Cornelius and his household receive the Spirit and speak in tongues; in Acts 19 the disciples at Ephesus receive the Spirit and speak in tongues. For Pentecostals, this pattern is normative — not merely descriptive of what happened historically, but prescriptive of what should happen in every age.

The language of "baptism in/with/of the Holy Spirit" comes from John the Baptist's promise (Matthew 3:11) and Jesus's command before the ascension (Acts 1:8): "You will receive power when the Holy Spirit comes upon you; and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem, and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the ends of the earth." The purpose of Spirit-baptism in classical Pentecostal theology is primarily missiological — it is empowerment for witness, not primarily sanctification (though that follows). The Spirit-baptized believer receives power to preach, to heal, to cast out demons, and to witness with supernatural effectiveness.

The experiential character of Spirit-baptism varies enormously across Pentecostal communities: in some, it is a sudden, overwhelming crisis experience; in others, it is a more gradual or quieter reception; in some, it is accompanied by extended prayer, fasting, and seeking; in others, it may come at a first service. What is consistent across Pentecostal traditions is the expectation that it will come — that it is available for all believers, that it should be actively sought, and that it can be received.

Seeking Spirit-baptism is a significant dimension of Pentecostal community life. Prayer meetings specifically aimed at receiving or renewing Spirit-baptism are common; laying on of hands (typically by elders or experienced believers) accompanies the prayer; extended periods of praise, singing in the Spirit, and what Pentecostals call "tarrying" (waiting on God with persistent prayer, based on Jesus's instruction to the disciples to "wait in Jerusalem" for the promised Spirit) characterize the seeking process. The receipt of Spirit-baptism is typically a community event — celebrated, affirmed, and witnessed by the gathered congregation.

Speaking in Tongues — Glossolalia as Initial Evidence

Speaking in tongues (glossolalia, from the Greek glossa — tongue/language, and lalia — speech) is the most controversial and most discussed distinctive of Pentecostal practice. In the classical Pentecostal understanding, tongues is the initial physical evidence of the baptism of the Holy Spirit — not the only gift, not the most important gift, but the specific sign that accompanies and confirms Spirit-baptism. When the Holy Spirit fills a believer with power, they speak in tongues.

Pentecostals distinguish between two distinct types of tongues. The first is the devotional gift of tongues — speaking in an unlearned language in personal prayer, which Paul describes in 1 Corinthians 14:2: "For anyone who speaks in a tongue does not speak to people but to God. Indeed, no one understands them; they utter mysteries by the Spirit." This devotional tongues, available to all Spirit-baptized believers, is the primary use of the gift in Pentecostal experience — a form of prayer in which the Spirit prays through the person in a language that transcends the person's own linguistic capacity, bypassing the mind and addressing God directly.

The second type is the public gift of tongues — a message in tongues directed to a gathered assembly, which requires interpretation. In 1 Corinthians 14, Paul instructs that tongues in the public gathering must be interpreted (by someone exercising the gift of interpretation of tongues) so that the congregation is edified. This public tongues + interpretation is understood to function as a form of prophetic speech — the Spirit speaking through an individual to the community.

The theological debate about tongues within Christianity is extensive. Cessationists (primarily in Reformed and some Baptist traditions) argue that the sign gifts (tongues, prophecy, healing, miracles) ceased with the death of the apostles and the completion of the New Testament canon — that they were temporary credentials for the apostolic era and are not normative for subsequent Christian experience. Continuationists (Pentecostals, charismatics, and many evangelicals) argue that there is no biblical basis for cessationism — no text that explicitly states that the gifts would end, and abundant evidence in church history that they have continued. The cessationist position depends significantly on a reading of 1 Corinthians 13:8-10 ("where there are tongues, they will be stilled; where there is knowledge, it will pass away... when completeness comes, what is in part disappears") as referring to the completion of the New Testament canon; the continuationist position reads "completeness" as referring to the return of Christ.

The Gifts of the Spirit — The Nine Charismata

The nine gifts of the Spirit listed in 1 Corinthians 12:8-10 are the charismata (plural of charisma — grace-gift) through which the Holy Spirit manifests in the life of the church. Pentecostal theology holds that all nine are available and normative in the contemporary church:

Gifts of Revelation

WORD OF WISDOM: Supernatural insight into the wisdom of God — a divinely imparted understanding of what to do in a specific situation that transcends natural wisdom. Distinguished from the gift of wisdom available to all believers (James 1:5) by its specific, supernaturally imparted character.

WORD OF KNOWLEDGE: Supernatural revelation of a specific fact — information about a person or situation that the speaker could not have known by natural means. Common in Pentecostal prayer ministry: "The Spirit is telling me that someone here has pain in their right shoulder..." The gift is controversial outside Pentecostal communities and is one of the practices most frequently associated with showmanship or manipulation.

DISCERNING OF SPIRITS: The supernatural ability to identify the spiritual source of a person's words or actions — whether they originate from the Holy Spirit, from human spirit, or from a demonic spirit. This gift is understood as essential for protecting the church from false prophecy and spiritual deception.

Gifts of Power

FAITH: A supernatural surge of confident trust in God for a specific situation — beyond ordinary saving faith, a specific charismatic faith that enables the person to pray or act with absolute certainty of divine response.

GIFTS OF HEALING: Supernatural healing of physical, emotional, or spiritual conditions through prayer and the laying on of hands. Plural in the Greek — each healing is a specific gift, given as the Spirit wills. This gift is one of the most visible and most theologically significant in Pentecostal practice; healing services, healing lines, and anointing with oil are characteristic Pentecostal practices.

WORKING OF MIRACLES: Supernatural interventions in the physical world that transcend natural law — including exorcism (casting out of demons), miraculous provision, and other sovereign acts of divine power.

Gifts of Utterance

PROPHECY: Inspired speech directed to a gathering — a message from God, typically in the first person ("Thus says the Lord..."), that brings encouragement, edification, comfort, correction, or revelation to the community. Paul calls prophecy the greatest of the gifts in its public utility (1 Corinthians 14:1-5) because it speaks directly to the hearers in their own language, unlike tongues. In Pentecostal theology, New Testament prophecy is not equivalent to Old Testament prophecy in its authority — it is "forthtelling" (speaking from God's perspective to the present situation) rather than necessarily "foretelling" (predicting the future). All prophecy in the gathered community is to be "tested" against Scripture and the discernment of the community.

TONGUES: As described in the previous section — the utterance of an unlearned language as personal devotional prayer (private) or as public speech requiring interpretation (corporate).

INTERPRETATION OF TONGUES: The supernatural ability to convey the meaning of a message spoken in tongues to the gathered community. The interpreter does not necessarily know the language being spoken — they receive the meaning supernaturally and convey it in the language of the community.

Divine Healing — By His Stripes We Are Healed

Divine healing is one of the most central and most contested elements of Pentecostal theology — the conviction that physical healing of the body is provided in the atonement of Christ and is available by faith for believers today. The primary scriptural texts are Isaiah 53:4-5 ("Surely he took up our pain and bore our suffering... and by his wounds we are healed") and Matthew 8:16-17 (Jesus's healing ministry described as fulfillment of Isaiah's prophecy). The argument: if Christ bore our sicknesses as well as our sins in his atoning work, then healing is as available as forgiveness — not necessarily automatic, but genuinely offered and receivable by faith.

The practice of healing prayer in Pentecostal communities takes several forms. Healing lines (also called prayer lines) — in which people who need healing come forward to receive prayer from a minister or healing evangelist — are the classic form associated with the great Pentecostal healing evangelists: Aimee Semple McPherson (1890-1944), who founded the International Church of the Foursquare Gospel and whose Los Angeles ministry attracted enormous crowds in the 1920s and 30s; William Branham (1909-1965), whose healing ministry in the 1940s and 50s brought dramatic testimonies of supernatural healing; Oral Roberts (1918-2009), whose television ministry brought healing prayer into American living rooms; and Kathryn Kuhlman (1907-1976), whose Pittsburgh and Los Angeles services drew tens of thousands and featured what participants described as sovereign, unsolicited healings in the audience.

James 5:14-16 provides the specific New Testament instruction for healing prayer: "Is anyone among you sick? Let them call the elders of the church to pray over them and anoint them with oil in the name of the Lord. And the prayer offered in faith will make the sick person well; the Lord will raise them up." The anointing with oil as an accompaniment to healing prayer is practiced in most Pentecostal traditions. The "prayer of faith" — the specific charismatic faith described in 1 Corinthians 12:9 — is understood as the mechanism through which healing is received.

The theology of divine healing raises serious ethical and pastoral challenges that Pentecostalism has not always navigated well. When expected healing does not occur, the person who was prayed for — or their family — is often left with a profound question: was my faith insufficient? Was my prayer not earnest enough? Was there unconfessed sin that blocked healing? These questions can produce profound guilt and spiritual injury in people who have prayed earnestly for healing and not received it. The most careful Pentecostal theologians affirm that healing is genuinely offered in the atonement while acknowledging that its reception depends on factors beyond human control — the sovereign will of God who knows what is ultimately best for each person — and that the absence of healing does not necessarily indicate any failure of faith.

The Fivefold Ministry

The fivefold ministry (also called the ascension gifts or Ephesians 4 gifts) is the Pentecostal and charismatic understanding of the offices of ministry described in Ephesians 4:11: "It was he who gave some to be apostles, some prophets, some evangelists, some pastors and teachers." Classical Pentecostalism recognized all five offices as continuing; the contemporary apostolic-prophetic movement has placed particular emphasis on the restoration of the offices of apostle and prophet as normative for contemporary church life.

APOSTLE: In the contemporary apostolic movement, an apostle is a trans-local leader who has authority across multiple congregations — who plants churches, raises up leaders, and establishes apostolic doctrine and order. This is distinct from the original twelve apostles, who were unique in their direct commissioning by Christ and their role in foundational revelation. The contemporary apostolic movement has been controversial both within and outside Pentecostal circles, with critics arguing that claims to apostolic authority have been used to justify spiritual abuse and financial exploitation.

PROPHET: A person who exercises the gift of prophecy in a consistent, recognized capacity — who speaks God's word to individuals, congregations, cities, and nations, and who may also have a function of intercessory prayer and spiritual warfare. The contemporary prophetic movement has faced significant criticism for prophecies that proved false (including several widely publicized failed prophecies about elections and world events), and for the culture of uncritical deference to prophetic figures that can develop in some communities.

EVANGELIST: A person specifically gifted to proclaim the Gospel to unbelievers and to move people to conversion. The classic Pentecostal evangelists — Billy Sunday (pre-Pentecostal but formative of the style), Aimee Semple McPherson, Oral Roberts, Kathryn Kuhlman — combined preaching with healing ministry in mass evangelistic campaigns. Today, evangelists range from itinerant healing ministers to megachurch pastors with enormous television and internet platforms.

PASTOR: The shepherd of a local congregation — providing ongoing teaching, care, and leadership. In most Pentecostal churches the pastor is the primary authority figure and the organizing center of congregational life.

TEACHER: A person who provides systematic instruction in Scripture and Christian doctrine. In Pentecostal communities, teaching often focuses on spiritual gifts, healing, spiritual warfare, and the prophetic — though the best Pentecostal teachers engage the full range of biblical and theological content.

Pentecostal Theology — Salvation and Sanctification

Pentecostal soteriology (doctrine of salvation) follows the pattern of the Wesleyan-Holiness tradition from which most classical Pentecostalism emerged: salvation involves repentance and faith in Christ's atoning work, producing the new birth (regeneration) and the forgiveness of sins. This initial salvation experience is then followed (in the three-stage Holiness Pentecostal model) by entire sanctification — the purification of the heart from the inherited sinful nature — and then by Spirit-baptism.

The specific Pentecostal contribution to soteriology is the integration of Spirit-baptism into the *ordo salutis* (order of salvation) as a distinct, normative, and expected experience. In the two-stage model (followed by many Baptist Pentecostals who do not affirm entire sanctification as a second definite work): (1) conversion/new birth, and (2) Spirit-baptism. In the three-stage model: (1) conversion/new birth, (2) entire sanctification, and (3) Spirit-baptism. In both models, Spirit-baptism is distinct from and subsequent to conversion — it does not save, but it empowers the saved person for witness and service.

The relationship between Spirit-baptism and assurance of salvation is nuanced. In most Pentecostal theology, a person can be genuinely saved without having received Spirit-baptism with tongues; speaking in tongues is evidence of Spirit-baptism, not of salvation itself. The person who has not yet spoken in tongues is not thereby condemned or spiritually deficient — but they are missing a resource of empowerment that God desires for them and that they should actively seek.

Oneness Pentecostalism — Jesus Only

Oneness Pentecostalism (also called the "Jesus Only" movement, the Apostolic movement, or "United Pentecostals") is a significant branch of the broader Pentecostal tradition that departed from Trinitarian theology in the 1910s and has remained a distinct and substantial movement ever since. Its primary denominational expression is the United Pentecostal Church International (UPCI), with approximately 4-5 million members globally.

The theological distinctives of Oneness Pentecostalism: God is absolutely one — not a Trinity of three persons but a single divine person who has revealed himself in the modes of Father (in creation and relationship), Son (in the incarnation of Jesus Christ), and Holy Spirit (in the spiritual work of regeneration and empowerment). Jesus Christ is the full embodiment of the Godhead — not the second person of the Trinity but the complete manifestation of the one God. Baptism must be administered "in the name of Jesus Christ" (following Acts 2:38) rather than in the Trinitarian formula of Matthew 28:19 — a claim with enormous practical implications, since Oneness Pentecostals typically do not recognize Trinitarian baptisms as valid.

Oneness Pentecostalism also emphasizes a specific "Acts 2:38 salvation" formula: repentance, water baptism in Jesus's name, and Spirit-baptism with speaking in tongues as the complete initiatory sequence required for salvation. This three-element sequence — repentance, baptism, Spirit-baptism — is understood as the apostolic formula for entering the kingdom of God, and the absence of any element (particularly baptism in Jesus's name and Spirit-baptism with tongues) raises questions about the completeness of one's salvation. This teaching is significantly more stringent than classical Trinitarian Pentecostalism and has been a source of controversy both within and outside the broader Pentecostal movement.

Pentecostal Worship — The Atmosphere of Heaven

Pentecostal worship is designed to create and sustain an encounter with the living God — not to manage a religious service but to host the manifest presence of the Holy Spirit. The aesthetic of Pentecostal worship is therefore radically different from the liturgical formality of Catholic, Orthodox, or traditional Protestant worship. There is no fixed order, no prescribed texts, no liturgical calendar that governs the specific character of each service. What there is — at least ideally, in the best expressions of the tradition — is a radical openness to the Spirit's movement, a willingness to follow the divine leading wherever it goes, and a community of people who expect that God will show up and do something specific in this gathering that has not been pre-planned or pre-arranged.

The physical expression of Pentecostal worship is characteristically exuberant. Raised hands (based on Psalm 134:2 and 1 Timothy 2:8) express praise and surrender. Clapping (Psalm 47:1) expresses joy. Shouting (Psalm 100:1) expresses spiritual intensity. Dancing (Psalm 149:3, 150:4) expresses joy and freedom. Prostration — lying face-down on the floor — expresses awe and contrition. "Holy laughter" (associated particularly with the Toronto Blessing revival of 1994 and the Brownsville Revival of 1995-2000) was reported as a sovereign manifestation of the Spirit's joy. "Being slain in the Spirit" — falling backward under the weight of the Spirit's presence when hands are laid on for prayer — is one of the most distinctive physical manifestations of Pentecostal experience.

These physical manifestations are not required or artificially produced (at their best); they are the natural expression of a community whose members have encountered the living God and whose bodies are responding. The community that has truly experienced the presence of God cannot remain physically still. The parallel in other sacred traditions is unmistakable: the Sufi who turns and weeps and lifts hands in dhikr, the Yoruba devotee whose body becomes the vehicle of the orisha's presence, the Pentecostal who falls under the weight of the Spirit — all are expressions of the sacred conviction that the body is the medium through which the divine encounter becomes most fully real.

A Pentecostal Service of Worship Step-by-Step

The following order represents a typical classical Pentecostal Sunday service. It should be noted that "typical" is a relative term — in Pentecostal theology, the Spirit can redirect any service at any moment, and the most significant spiritual moments often occur when the planned order is suspended and the Spirit is followed wherever it leads.

Praise and Worship

PRAISE: The service typically opens with a period of energetic congregational praise — songs of celebration, joy, and exuberance. The worship leader leads the congregation into increasingly focused engagement with God. Songs may be repeated multiple times; the repetition is not monotonous but meditative — allowing the lyrics to sink deeper with each repetition. In contemporary Pentecostal contexts: modern praise and worship songs (Hillsong, Elevation Worship, Bethel Music); in traditional contexts: classic Pentecostal hymns and gospel songs.

TRANSITION TO WORSHIP: The energy gradually shifts from the exuberant celebration of praise to the quieter, more intimate atmosphere of worship. Songs become slower, more personal, more directed toward the presence of God rather than statements about God.

CONGREGATIONAL PRAYER: A period of simultaneous, often audible prayer by the entire congregation — a distinctive Pentecostal practice that can sound cacophonous to those unfamiliar with it but that represents the community's collective verbal engagement with God. People speak or sing their prayers aloud, sometimes in tongues, sometimes in their native language. The effect is a sound of corporate intercession and praise.

SINGING IN THE SPIRIT: A distinctive Pentecostal practice in which the congregation spontaneously sings simultaneously in tongues and in their native language — creating an unscripted, Spirit-led harmony that participants describe as one of the most remarkable experiences of Pentecostal worship. No one is leading; no one planned this; yet it comes together as a corporate act of Spirit-led worship.

THE OPEN MOVE OF THE SPIRIT: In the most open Pentecostal services, this period of extended worship may produce prophecy (an individual receives a message from God and delivers it to the congregation), a public message in tongues followed by interpretation, a healing spontaneously manifesting in someone's body, or other Spirit-led occurrences that redirect the service.

Word and Response

OFFERING AND ANNOUNCEMENTS: Practical business of the congregation.

SCRIPTURE AND SERMON: The preaching of the Word — typically expository or topical, delivered with energy and passion, and aimed at both intellectual understanding and the experiential appropriation of divine truth. Pentecostal preaching at its best combines solid biblical exposition with vivid storytelling, frequent direct address to the congregation, and a sustained expectation that the Holy Spirit will move through the preached Word to heal, deliver, and transform.

HEALING AND MINISTRY TIME: After the sermon, a significant proportion of Pentecostal services include an extended period of prayer ministry — an invitation for those needing healing, deliverance, breakthrough, or Spirit-baptism to come forward. Elders, ministers, or trained prayer teams lay hands on and pray for individuals. This ministry time may be as long as or longer than the sermon itself.

THE ALTAR CALL: An invitation to receive Christ for the first time, or to respond to a specific spiritual conviction produced by the service. Respondents come forward; counselors meet with them; the congregation prays.

DISMISSAL: A closing prayer and blessing as the congregation is released.

Prayer in Pentecostal Life

Prayer occupies a central and expansive place in Pentecostal spirituality — not merely as a devotional practice but as the primary arena of spiritual warfare, healing, intercession, and encounter with God. The range of Pentecostal prayer practices is wide.

PERSONAL PRAYER IN TONGUES: The daily practice of praying in tongues — speaking to God in the Spirit language — is considered by many Pentecostals to be the most important dimension of their prayer life. Paul's statement in 1 Corinthians 14:4 ("Anyone who speaks in a tongue edifies themselves") grounds this practice: praying in tongues builds up the individual spirit even when the mind is not engaged. Paul also claims to "pray in tongues more than all of you" (1 Corinthians 14:18), suggesting this was a significant personal discipline.

INTERCESSORY PRAYER: Extended prayer on behalf of others — for healing, for salvation, for specific needs, for nations. Pentecostal intercessory prayer is typically vocal, specific, and fervent. The idea of "praying through" — persisting in prayer until a sense of spiritual breakthrough is received — is a classic Pentecostal concept.

SPIRITUAL WARFARE PRAYER: Prayer directed at demonic forces — binding and loosing (based on Matthew 18:18: "whatever you bind on earth will be bound in heaven..."), interceding for deliverance from spiritual oppression, and claiming territory for the kingdom of God. Spiritual warfare prayer can be intense and confrontational in style — directly addressing demonic forces, commanding them to depart, and asserting the authority of Christ over specific situations.

PRAYER AND FASTING: Extended periods of combined fasting (abstaining from food) and prayer are a significant Pentecostal practice, particularly for serious spiritual needs. The biblical precedent (Matthew 17:21 — "this kind goes out only by prayer and fasting"; Acts 13:2-3 — the Spirit speaks during fasting) grounds this practice. Pentecostal churches often organize congregational prayer and fasting periods — 21 days, 40 days — for breakthrough in specific situations.

PRAYER ROOMS AND HOUSES OF PRAYER: The 24/7 Prayer movement, begun by Mike Bickle and the International House of Prayer in Kansas City (IHOPKC) in 1999, has spread globally — a Pentecostal-influenced movement of continuous prayer (24 hours a day, 7 days a week) offered as a form of corporate intercession and worship. IHOPKC's model of combining live worship music with intercessory prayer in continuous shifts has been replicated in hundreds of prayer houses worldwide.

The Charismatic Renewal — The Spirit Enters the Mainline

The charismatic renewal was the movement of Pentecostal experience and practice into the historic mainline denominations beginning in the 1960s. If the Azusa Street Revival was the fire that ignited Pentecostalism, the charismatic renewal was the fire that spread it beyond Pentecostal denominational boundaries into the established churches of Christianity.

The traditional starting point is April 3, 1960, when Dennis Bennett, an Episcopal priest in Van Nuys, California, announced to his congregation that he had spoken in tongues. Bennett was asked to resign; he transferred to a struggling Episcopal mission in Seattle that became a major charismatic center. His account of the experience, *Nine O'Clock in the Morning* (1970), became one of the most widely read books of the charismatic renewal.

Through the 1960s and 70s, charismatic experience spread through Episcopal, Lutheran, Presbyterian, Methodist, Catholic, and eventually Baptist communities. The Catholic Charismatic Renewal — which began at Duquesne University in 1967 and spread to Notre Dame and beyond — became one of the most significant renewal movements in 20th-century Catholicism, producing prayer groups in thousands of Catholic parishes worldwide and eventually receiving the cautious encouragement of Pope Paul VI and enthusiastic affirmation from Pope John Paul II.

The charismatic renewal produced a new form of worship that has since become the dominant mode of evangelical Protestant worship globally: contemporary worship music (praise and worship songs with a band rather than traditional hymns with piano/organ), raised hands and physical expressiveness in worship, small group prayer with expectation of spiritual gifts, and a generally less formal approach to Christian community. The Australian worship collectives Hillsong (founded 1983) and their successors, the American-based Bethel Music and Elevation Worship — all with deep charismatic roots — have produced music that is now sung in evangelical churches of every denomination worldwide.

Neo-Pentecostalism and the Word of Faith Movement

Neo-Pentecostalism is the broad term for the forms of Pentecostal and charismatic Christianity that emerged from the 1970s onward, often characterized by independent megachurches, celebrity pastors, television ministries, elaborate worship productions, and theological innovations that depart significantly from classical Pentecostalism. The Word of Faith movement (also called Health and Wealth, Name It and Claim It, or Prosperity Gospel) is the most significant and most controversial of these neo-Pentecostal theological streams.

The Word of Faith movement developed primarily through the ministry of Kenneth Hagin Sr. (1917-2003), who is generally regarded as its founding theological figure, and was spread through the ministries of Kenneth Copeland, Benny Hinn, Creflo Dollar, Joel Osteen, Joyce Meyer, and many others with enormous television and media platforms. Its theological framework draws on a reading of Mark 11:23-24 ("I tell you the truth, if anyone says to this mountain, 'Go, throw yourself into the sea,' and does not doubt in their heart but believes that what they say will happen, it will be done for them. Therefore I tell you, whatever you ask for in prayer, believe that you have received it, and it will be yours") and on specific theological claims about the power of faith and the spoken word.

Word of Faith theology teaches: that God operates in the world through the vehicle of faith — specifically, confessed, spoken faith; that the believer who speaks God's Word with genuine faith can "call things that are not as though they were" (Romans 4:17) and thereby create the realities they declare; that sickness, poverty, and failure are not God's will for believers and can be overcome through positive confession of Scripture; and that physical health and material prosperity are covenant rights of the believer, available through faith and proper confession. The phrase "name it and claim it" captures the popular understanding of this theology.

The controversy around Word of Faith theology is extensive and serious. Critics — both from within Pentecostal theology and from outside — argue that it misrepresents Scripture by taking specific texts out of context; that it creates false expectations of healing and prosperity that damage people whose prayers for healing or financial blessing are not answered; that it obscures the New Testament teaching about suffering, the cross, and the sanctifying purpose of hardship; and that it has been used to extract enormous financial resources from poor and desperate people through the mechanism of the "prosperity seed offering" (the teaching that financial giving to the ministry of the Word of Faith teacher will be multiplied back to the giver many times over). Serious Pentecostal theologians (Vinson Synan, Gordon Fee, Gordon Anderson) have consistently criticized Word of Faith theology as a departure from biblical Christianity.

Prosperity Gospel — Blessing and Controversy

The prosperity gospel (also called the health-and-wealth gospel or name-it-and-claim-it theology) is the specific theological claim that physical health and material wealth are God's will for all believers and are available through faith, positive confession, and giving to God's work. It is distinct from classical Pentecostalism, which affirms divine healing but does not promise guaranteed material prosperity as a covenant right.

The biblical arguments for prosperity theology draw primarily on Abraham's material wealth as a paradigm of covenant blessing (Galatians 3:14: "He redeemed us... so that by faith we might receive the promise of the Spirit" — and the blessings of Abraham are understood to include material as well as spiritual blessing); on Deuteronomy 28's catalogue of material blessings for obedience; on John 10:10 ("I have come that they may have life, and have it to the full"); and on 3 John 2 ("Beloved, I pray that you may prosper in all things and be in health, just as your soul prospers").

The prosperity gospel has been severely criticized by theological scholars of virtually every tradition — including many prominent Pentecostal scholars — for its selective use of Scripture, its ignoring of the substantial New Testament teaching about suffering and the cross (Paul's thorn in the flesh, the Beatitudes, Jesus's statement that his followers would share his cross), and its practical effects on vulnerable people. The Lausanne Theology Working Group's 2010 "Prosperity Gospel" paper, signed by evangelical scholars from many traditions, described prosperity theology as "a false gospel" that corrupts the true Gospel and exploits the poor.

Despite these theological critiques, prosperity theology has spread globally with extraordinary speed, particularly in the developing world — in Nigeria, Brazil, South Korea, and the Philippines — where it offers a religious framework in which faith is a means of escaping poverty and achieving flourishing. The theologian Amos Yong has argued that the popularity of prosperity theology in the Global South cannot be dismissed as merely the exploitation of the poor; it also represents a genuine theological response to the real human desire for abundant life and the intuition that God's purposes include human flourishing in all its dimensions.

The Assemblies of God

The Assemblies of God (AG) is the world's largest Pentecostal denomination, founded in Hot Springs, Arkansas in April 1914, and now representing a fellowship of approximately 69 million members in approximately 400,000 churches in 191 countries. It is also the fastest-growing major Protestant denomination in the United States, with approximately 3.3 million members and 13,000 churches.

The Assemblies of God was founded when Pentecostal ministers met to organize a cooperative structure for missions, education, and the credentialing of ministers — not to establish a denomination (most Pentecostals at the time were suspicious of denominational structures as quenching the Spirit) but to create cooperative resources for the growing movement. William Durham's "Finished Work" theology — which rejected the Holiness Pentecostal three-stage salvation sequence in favor of a two-stage model (conversion + Spirit-baptism, without a separate entire sanctification) — became the dominant theological position of the AG, distinguishing it from the Holiness Pentecostal bodies (Church of God, Pentecostal Holiness Church) that maintained the Wesleyan three-stage framework.

The AG's "Statement of Fundamental Truths" (1916) affirms: the inspiration and inerrancy of Scripture; the Trinity; the fall of humanity; salvation by grace through faith; water baptism by immersion; the baptism of the Holy Spirit with initial evidence of speaking in tongues; the gifts of the Spirit; divine healing; and the premillennial, pretribulational return of Christ. The AG does not ordain women as senior pastors in most of its constituencies (though women have served in many ministry capacities throughout its history, and Aimee Semple McPherson was AG-ordained before she founded the Foursquare Church).

Church of God in Christ — The Black Pentecostal Tradition

The Church of God in Christ (COGIC) is the largest Black Pentecostal denomination in the United States and the second largest Pentecostal denomination in the country overall, with approximately 6.5 million members in approximately 12,000 congregations. It was founded in 1896 by Charles Harrison Mason (1866-1961) and Charles Price Jones as a Holiness church, and became explicitly Pentecostal after Mason visited the Azusa Street Revival in 1907 and returned with the Pentecostal experience.

Mason's COGIC ordained White Pentecostal ministers at a time when there were no White Pentecostal denominations — the Assemblies of God was not founded until 1914 — making Mason the source of ordination credentials for many White Pentecostal ministers in the early years of the movement. When the Assemblies of God was founded, most White ministers who had been ordained by Mason transferred to the new organization; the racial separation of early Pentecostalism — the tragedy of the Azusa Street vision's failure to produce a genuinely integrated denomination — was replicated in the organizational structure of American Pentecostalism.

COGIC worship is the tradition that most directly carries the African American musical and spiritual heritage into the Pentecostal context. The COGIC musical tradition — combining gospel piano, Hammond organ, call-and-response preaching, choral arrangements, and the full expressive range of African American sacred music — has been one of the most significant influences on American popular music. Gospel music as a genre emerged from COGIC and related Black Pentecostal communities; the gospel style of Thomas Dorsey, Mahalia Jackson, the Clark Sisters, Kirk Franklin, and countless others traces directly to COGIC worship. The COGIC Annual Holy Convocation — held in Memphis, Tennessee every November — is one of the largest annual religious gatherings in the United States.

Global Pentecostalism — The Fastest-Growing Movement in History

Global Pentecostalism is the most significant religious phenomenon of the 20th and early 21st centuries — a movement that began with fewer than a hundred people in a Los Angeles warehouse in 1906 and has grown to encompass approximately 700 million people, representing perhaps a quarter to a third of all Christians worldwide when charismatic variants are included. No religious movement in human history has grown at this rate across this many cultures and contexts simultaneously.

The mechanisms of Pentecostal growth vary by context. In North America and Europe, Pentecostalism has grown primarily through the charismatic renewal (bringing Pentecostal experience into established denominations) and through independent megachurches that have developed from charismatic and Pentecostal roots. In Latin America, Africa, and Asia, growth has occurred through direct evangelism, the planting of new congregations, and the translation of Pentecostal practice into local cultural idioms.

The global spread of Pentecostalism has also generated a phenomenon of indigenous innovation: Pentecostal communities in Nigeria, Brazil, South Korea, Guatemala, and Indonesia have not merely adopted American Pentecostalism but have developed their own theological emphases, worship styles, and ministry structures that are now sending missionaries back to the Global North. The Redeemed Christian Church of God, founded in Nigeria in 1952, has planted congregations in 196 countries; the Yoido Full Gospel Church in Seoul, South Korea, founded by David Cho Yonggi in 1958, grew to a reported membership of 830,000, making it for many years the largest single congregation in the world.

Pentecostalism in the Global South

The Global South — Latin America, sub-Saharan Africa, and parts of Asia — is where Pentecostalism has grown most explosively and where its future lies. In these contexts, Pentecostal Christianity is not a minority tradition competing with secular culture; in many areas it is the dominant form of Christianity and a primary vehicle of social transformation.

LATIN AMERICA: Pentecostalism has fundamentally altered the religious landscape of Latin America, where it emerged in Brazil in 1910 and has grown to represent approximately 25-30% of Latin America's population, with the strongest concentrations in Brazil, Chile, Guatemala, and El Salvador. The growth has been most dramatic among the urban poor, for whom Pentecostal communities have provided not only spiritual resources but practical community support networks, healing (in a context of limited healthcare access), identity and dignity, and a framework for understanding and addressing the social and economic conditions of poverty. The prosperity gospel's appeal in this context is comprehensible: it offers a theology of divine provision that speaks directly to communities experiencing material deprivation.

SUB-SAHARAN AFRICA: Pentecostal and charismatic Christianity is the fastest-growing religious category in sub-Saharan Africa, where it has blended with indigenous African religious sensibilities around healing, the spirit world, and the practical power of sacred practice. The resonance between traditional African religious frameworks (in which spirits are active agents in daily life, healing is a primary religious function, and sacred power is available through authorized practitioners) and Pentecostal theology (in which the Spirit is powerfully present, healing is available by faith, and spiritual gifts enable engagement with the spiritual world) has made Pentecostalism extraordinarily effective in African contexts. Nigeria alone has more than 20 million Pentecostals in the Redeemed Christian Church of God, the Winners' Chapel, the Church of God Mission, and hundreds of other bodies.

SOUTH KOREA: The Republic of Korea is perhaps the most striking example of Pentecostal growth in Asia — a country that was approximately 3% Christian in 1945 and is now approximately 29% Christian (Protestant and Catholic combined), with the Protestant majority having a strong Pentecostal/charismatic character. The Yoido Full Gospel Church in Seoul is the paradigmatic example: founded in a tent by David Yonggi Cho in 1958 with 5 members, it grew to 830,000 registered members by the early 21st century through its cell group structure, its healing ministry, its prosperity-adjacent theology, and its fasting and prayer culture. Korean Pentecostalism has sent thousands of missionaries worldwide and has been one of the primary engines of global Pentecostal expansion.

Pentecostalism and Social Justice

The relationship between Pentecostalism and social justice has been complex and frequently misunderstood. Early Pentecostalism — particularly in its Azusa Street origins — was genuinely transgressive on matters of race, class, and gender: it was an interracial movement in Jim Crow America, it elevated Black leadership, it gave prominent roles to women in a culture that excluded them from public ministry, and it drew its earliest constituency from the urban poor and the social margins.

As Pentecostalism institutionalized and began to attract middle-class adherents, its social radicalism largely faded. The racial segregation that Azusa Street had briefly transcended was reproduced in the organizational structures of American Pentecostalism — the Assemblies of God and the Church of God in Christ developed as parallel but separate organizations, and the integrated worship vision of William Seymour was not sustained. By the mid-20th century, American Pentecostalism was largely aligned with the conservative political and social culture of American evangelicalism.

The contemporary landscape is more nuanced. COGIC and the Black Pentecostal tradition have remained consistently connected to the civil rights tradition and to ongoing advocacy for racial justice. The Pentecostal movement in Latin America has produced both conservative political allies (in countries like Brazil) and liberation-theology-adjacent communities that combine Pentecostal experience with advocacy for the poor. The "Social Gospel Pentecostalism" represented by scholars like Samuel Solivan and Eldin Villafane argues that authentic Pentecostalism — rooted in the Spirit's empowerment of the marginalized — is inherently a justice-oriented movement, and that the political conservatism of American Pentecostalism is a cultural distortion rather than a theological necessity.

The Haligricity Lens — The Spirit Poured Out on All Flesh

Pentecostalism offers the Haligric practitioner the most immediate, the most experiential, and the most physically engaged of all the Christian tradition's articulations of what it means to encounter the divine. Where Orthodoxy speaks of theosis as a gradual, carefully ordered transformation; where Lutheranism speaks of grace received through the objective word of promise; where Calvinism speaks of election secured in God's eternal decree — Pentecostalism speaks of an experience that happens now, in the body, in the voice, in the immediate present moment of the gathered community.

The Spirit Poured Out on All Flesh — Universal Sacred Availability

The Pentecostal movement's governing scripture is Peter's proclamation on the day of Pentecost (Acts 2:17, quoting Joel 2:28): "In the last days, God says, I will pour out my Spirit on all people. Your sons and daughters will prophesy, your young men will see visions, your old men will dream dreams." The critical words are "all people" — all flesh, all humanity, without distinction. The Spirit is not reserved for the educated, the ordained, the theologically trained, or the morally perfect. The Spirit is poured out on old and young, male and female, slave and free (as Paul states in Galatians 3:28). This is the Pentecostal version of what the Haligric tradition holds about the universal availability of the sacred: the divine presence is not the possession of a spiritual elite but the gift of a God whose generosity recognizes no human limitation.

The Body as the Site of Sacred Encounter

The Pentecostal tradition's most distinctive gift to the Haligric practitioner is its insistence that the encounter with the sacred is fundamentally embodied — that the Holy Spirit manifests in and through the body, not merely in the mind or the spirit. The person who speaks in tongues is not having an intellectual experience; their voice is doing something their intellect cannot do, something that bypasses the reasoning faculty and expresses the Spirit directly through the body. The person who falls under the Spirit's presence is not pretending or performing; their body is responding to a reality their mind cannot fully process. The person who is healed is not having a spiritual metaphor — their physical body is being transformed by divine power. The Pentecostal insistence on embodied sacred experience connects directly to what the African drum ceremony knows, what the Sufi's turn in dhikr knows, what the Orthodox triple immersion knows: the sacred comes to the body, and the body's knowing is not inferior to the mind's knowing.

All Flesh — The Radical Inclusivity of the Spirit

The most profound theological gift of Azusa Street was not tongues but integration — the Spirit's dismantling of the racial hierarchy that governed American society in 1906. For a brief period, in a dilapidated building in Los Angeles, black and white worshipped together under black leadership, in defiance of every social norm and legal structure of the time. William Seymour's vision — that the Spirit was creating a new kind of human community in which the walls of race, denomination, class, and gender would be dissolved — was not fully sustained in institutional form. But it was a genuine prophetic sign of what the Spirit's purposes are: not to create a new religious institution but to forge a new humanity. "On all flesh" means on all flesh — without exception. Grand Rising.